

## Services

### THE IMPACT

Barely three years after its launch on August 15, 2005, the unique 108 service is operating 652 ambulances in Andhra Pradesh, 400 in Gujarat, 50 in Uttarakhand, 18 in Goa, 20 in Tamil Nadu, 11 in Rajasthan and 66 in Karnataka.

now has 400 ambulances covering 26 districts. Uttarakhand launched the service on May 15 this year and has a fleet of 30 ambulances deployed across 19 districts. The fleet is to be expanded to 90 by March next year. Goa has introduced 15 ambulances, while Rajasthan and Tamil Nadu plan to have 150 and 198 ambulances by March. When services are available in the nine states, EMRI will cover a population greater than 300 million with more than 2,200 ambulances, making it the

spond faster. They identify dangerous intersections and pass the information to state governments to encourage better traffic management. Even though emergency ambulance services are handled by states, the Union Health Ministry and the National Disaster Management Authority are keen on the service being available across the country.

The Government has reserved 108 as the toll-free number, but the evolution of a centralised emergency management service for the entire country remains sluggish. There are plans to create an Indian Emergency Management Authority to enable states operate emergency response centres. The work done by EMRI has been transformative. Anil Jampala, a lead partner at EMRI, says, "For long, if someone collapsed or fell down, people believed that there should be bleeding for an emergency to happen. We have already influenced a change in that understanding."

Raju has roped in former President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam as the chairman emeritus, and management consultant Rajat Gupta, Harvard Business School don Krishna Palepu and robotics professor at Carnegie Mellon University, Raj Reddy on EMRI's governing board. "Our goal is to respond to a million calls every day and save one million lives a year nationally by 2010," says Raju. The plan is to oversee 11,000 ambulances, 25 call centres, five research and training centres, and one lakh personnel to serve 1.1 billion people nationwide by 2010.

EMRI has launched a two-year training programme for paramedics in partnership with the Stanford School of Medicine, USA. It estimates that India would require more than 11,000 ambulances and at least 35,000 trained paramedics for a spread-out emergency network. If all states sign on for the EMRI service and make appropriate investments, the goal of saving a life anywhere with emergency medical care can be achieved soon. ■



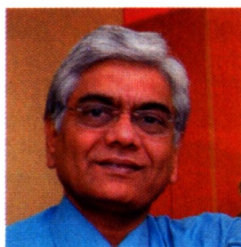
AN EMRI VAN GETS GOING ON A RESCUE MISSION

### THE EXPANSION

Gujarat and Goa have the distinction of having the entire planned fleet on the roads with 2,205 and 119 staff respectively. Andhra Pradesh is to add 150 ambulances, Uttarakhand another 40 and Tamil Nadu another 198 by the end of the year. Rajasthan is to add 150 ambulances while Karnataka will have 110 by March 2009.

world's largest integrated emergency services provider. Even as this roll out is underway, Kerala, Maharashtra, Jammu and Kashmir, Punjab and Delhi are planning to build similar networks with the help of EMRI to take the total to 5,000 ambulances reaching out to 480 million people by mid-2009.

EMRI has 7,466 staffers, including 107 doctors, 3,601 paramedics, 2,797 drivers, and 401 call centre operators to respond round the clock and a support staff of nearly 560. Doctors double as researchers at EMRI and track emergency calls to position ambulances in better spots to re-



**"There's a need to integrate agencies to provide emergency response."** VENKAT CHENGAVALLI, CEO, EMRI